

Setting up how a league works

Season calendars, competition structures, running a season stage by stage, and allocating grounds. A complete walkthrough for the union office.

HOW A FIXTURE COMES TO EXIST



Who this is for

Platform operators setting a client up, and union administrators running the season. No technical knowledge assumed.

2026 / 27

Season
Version 1.0

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PART ONE

How a season is put together

Before any clicking, four ideas. They take five minutes and they make the rest of this guide obvious rather than fiddly.

A league is not a competition

In the old model a league was just a name, and it ran one flat round robin. That works for EMCU Division 2. It does not work for KZNCU Premier Men, which runs **two competitions at once**: a T20 Pink Ball tournament in seeded pools, and a 50 Over Red Ball league split into a Top Six and a Bottom Six.

So a league now holds one or more **competitions**. Each competition is a format stream with its own shape and its own dates. The same twelve clubs can be in both, grouped completely differently.

A competition is a pipeline of stages

A stage is one phase of play. Premier Men 50 Over has two: a double round robin, then a final round after the mid-season swap. Each stage answers three questions, and only three.

THE QUESTION	WHAT YOU CHOOSE
Who plays?	Every registered side · seeded into groups · entered by an administrator
Who plays whom?	Round robin (1, 2 or 3 legs) · knockout · single match · entered by hand
When?	Which playing block, and at what cadence

WHY SO FEW OPTIONS

The list is deliberately short and closed. Every one of the thirteen documented KZNCU and EMCU structures is expressible with these pieces, and a shorter list is a list you can hold in your head. If something genuinely doesn't fit, that is a conversation with the platform team, not a setting.

One group becomes one series

When a stage generates, each of its groups becomes a **series** — the same thing the platform has always had. So approving, releasing, the player broadcast and the travel-cost figures all work exactly as they do today. Nothing new to learn there.

A Top Six therefore produces one series and a Bottom Six another. In the club portal those appear under a single season heading, so a club sees one competition rather than two loose lists.

Standings are typed by a human, on purpose

The platform does not record results. There is no ladder. That means a stage which depends on finishing order — the mid-season swap, the top four qualifying for semi-finals — cannot work itself out.

Rather than pretend, such a stage stops and asks. It quotes the rule back to you in the operator's own words, proposes the best grouping it honestly can, and waits. What you chose, what was proposed, and whether you accepted it are all recorded against your name.

THE ONE THING TO TAKE FROM PART ONE

The operator builds the *shape* once. The administrator runs the *season* through it every year, filling in the things only a human knows. Those are two different jobs, done by two different people, at two different times.

Season calendars

Start here. Structures reference calendars, and leagues reference both, so the calendar has to exist before anything can point at it.

A season is not one continuous window. The KZNCU season is two **blocks** with a mid-season break between them: roughly 13 September to 13 December, then nothing until the third week of January, then through to the end of March.

Getting this right is what stops a ten-round league quietly scheduling its last three rounds into the Christmas holidays.

Building one

1

Open the operator console and find `Season calendars`

It sits on the client's settings page, above Venues and the structure library.

2

Give it a label you'll recognise next year

`2026/27` is enough. This is what administrators see when they start a season, so it should read the way the union talks about the season.

3

Add a block for each continuous stretch of play

Name it the way the union names it — `Block 1`, `First half`, whatever people actually say. Then set the first and last date on which a match could be played.

Dates are `YYYY-MM-DD`. A block that ends before it starts is refused, as is 31 February.

4

Add the breaks

A break is a stretch inside the season when nobody plays. Fixture generation steps *over* a break rather than dropping the rounds that would have fallen in it, so a ten-round league still gets ten rounds, just later.

5

Add excluded dates

Single days that are out: public holidays, exam weekends, the union's own AGM. Same behaviour as a break, just for one day.

BEFORE YOU SAVE

A calendar a series is already scheduled against cannot be deleted. The platform will refuse and tell you which competitions are using it. That is deliberate — deleting it would strand a season nobody could regenerate.

What good looks like

FIELD	KZNCU 2026/27
Label	2026/27
Block 1	13 Sep 2026 → 13 Dec 2026
Block 2	18 Jan 2027 → 28 Mar 2027
Break	Mid-season break · 14 Dec 2026 → 17 Jan 2027
Excluded	24 Sep 2026 (Heritage Day)

Venues

The master list of grounds fixtures can be played at. Second, because the allocator needs it and because you can seed most of it automatically.

Seed it from the clubs you already have

Clubs have already told you their grounds during affiliation. The **Sync from club records** button reads every club's primary and secondary ground and creates a venue for each, with the club attached as a home side.

Two clubs naming the same ground get one venue with both attached. Ground-sharing is routine in club cricket and the allocator needs to know about it — it is exactly why "play at home" sometimes cannot be satisfied for both sides on the same Saturday.

Then pin the coordinates by hand

THERE IS NO GEOCODER

The platform cannot look up a ground's position from its address. Somebody has to type the latitude and longitude. Secondary grounds have no coordinates at all in the club records, so they always start unpinned.

This matters more than it sounds. The allocator ranks grounds partly by travel, and a ground with no position would otherwise look like it is zero kilometres from everywhere and win every time.

So the Venues card shows a **coverage figure**: the share of grounds that have a position. Below 60%, the allocator switches distance ranking off entirely and falls back to home-ground preference alone. It tells you it has done this rather than quietly producing worse answers.

Getting a latitude and longitude is a thirty-second job: find the ground in Google Maps, right-click the middle of the square, and the first line of the menu is the pair of numbers. Durban grounds look like **-29.85** and **31.03** — southern latitudes are negative.

The fields, and what each one changes

FIELD	WHAT IT DOES
Ground name	What clubs and players see on the schedule. Required.
Suburb, Address	Display only. Helpful on a printed fixture list.
Latitude / Longitude	Enables distance ranking. Optional, but see the coverage note above.
Matches per day	How many fixtures can be played here on one date. A two-pitch ground takes two. Default 1.
Home clubs	Which clubs call this home. Drives the "play at home" preference.
Unavailable windows	Maintenance, another sport's season, an exam period. Needs a reason — the reason is shown to the administrator when a fixture gets moved.
Unavailable weekdays	A ground that is never free on Sundays.

REASONS ARE NOT PAPERWORK

When the allocator moves a fixture it quotes your reason back: "*Home ground outfield relaid — moved to the away side's ground.*" A club secretary can argue with that. They cannot argue with a fixture that simply appeared somewhere unexpected.

Competition structures

The shape of a competition, built once and reused. This is the heart of the feature and the part worth taking slowly.

Start from a template, almost always

Four templates ship, and between them they cover all thirteen documented KZNCU and EMCU structures. A template is a **copy**, not a link — once you pick one it is yours and fully editable, and changing it later never affects anything else.

TEMPLATE	USE IT FOR
Flat round robin	Every EMCU division. One stage, everyone plays everyone.
Split league with mid-season swap	KZNCU Premier Men 50 Over, Premier Women 30 Over.
Seeded pools → cross-pool semis → final	Every T20 Pink Ball competition.
Stream + knockout cup	Promotion Men — streams plus the Kingsmead Cup.

Build from scratch is there when nothing fits, and **Import JSON** is how you move a structure between clients or seed several at once without twenty rounds of clicking.

Reading a stage

Collapsed, each stage is one plain sentence. That sentence is the point — you should be able to read a whole structure without expanding anything.



The four controls inside a stage

Format — who plays whom

CHOICE	MEANING
Single round robin	Everyone plays everyone once.
Double round robin	Twice, home and away. The second leg mirrors the first.
Triple round robin	Three times. Rare, but the model supports it.
Knockout — seeded	Standard bracket from the entrant order. Top two seeds can only meet in the final. A field that isn't a power of two gets a preliminary round automatically.
Knockout — cross-pool	Pool winners paired against other pools' runners-up. Needs the previous stage's finishing positions — see Part Six.
Single match	One fixture. A final, a playoff.
Entered by hand	The escape hatch. Generates no fixtures; the administrator adds them manually afterwards.

Teams — where the entrants come from

CHOICE	MEANING
Every registered side	Everyone entered in the league. One group.
Seeded into groups	Split by seeding order. Snake puts seeds 1 and 2 in different pools; top-down blocks puts the top half in one group.
Entered by an administrator	A human types the groups. Used whenever the answer depends on standings.

For the last two you also set the group plan: **even groups** (say 4 groups, remainder lands in the earlier ones) or **exact sizes** (5, 5, 5, 4 — the only way to express the 19-team Promotion Men split).

The rule, for administrator-entered stages

When a stage depends on an earlier one, write the rule in plain English. This sentence is shown to the administrator when they confirm, and it is the whole instruction they get:

Top Six 6th ↔ Bottom Six 1st, carrying the outgoing position's points

Tick **points move with the position** if the swap carries points. The administrator then gets a box to enter them, and they are recorded as carried rather than calculated.

Schedule — when it is played

CADENCE	MEANING
Weekly	One round per week.
Every N weeks	Fortnightly for EMCU Division 3 Stream 2 and Division 4.
Set days only	Saturdays only, for EMCU Division 5.
Spread across block	Rounds spaced evenly to fill the block.

You can also add **time slots** (a T20 morning and afternoon), and an **activation date** — junior fixtures generated in September but not visible to clubs until the third week of January.

Watch the preview rail

The panel beside the editor recalculates on every change, for a hypothetical number of teams you set. It shows fixture counts per group, rounds against cadence, the resulting date span, and whether it fits the block.

THIS IS WHERE MISTAKES GET CAUGHT

"11 rounds × every 2 weeks = 22 weeks. Block 1 is 13 weeks — 9 weeks over."

That is the EMCU Division 4 problem, found at design time in the operator console rather than in February with a club secretary on the phone. Shorten the cadence, split across blocks, or extend the block.

Binding a competition to a league

The last operator step, and the one that makes everything else reachable. Until a league has a competition, an administrator cannot start a season on it.

Open **Leagues** in the operator console and add a competition to the league. Each competition needs four things:

FIELD	EXAMPLE
Label	50 Over (Red Ball)
Structure	Split league with mid-season swap
Calendar	2026/27
Match format	50 overs, red ball

Add a second competition to the same league for the T20 stream, pointing at a different structure. Those are the two competitions Premier Men runs in parallel.

TWO CROSS-CHECKS HAPPEN ON SAVE

The structure and calendar must both still exist, and every stage's playing block must exist on the bound calendar. A structure whose stages reference "Block 2" cannot be bound to a single-block calendar — you get told which stage and which calendar, on save, rather than months later at generation time.

NOTHING BREAKS IF YOU STOP HERE

A league with no competition behaves exactly as it always has: the administrator uses **Create a series** and gets a flat round robin. Structured seasons are opt-in, league by league.

Running a season

The operator's work is done. This is the part the union office does every year.

Start it

1 Admin console → Seasons → Start a season

Pick the league, then the competition, then confirm the season label. If the league has no competition configured you will be told so plainly and pointed at your platform operator.

2 The structure and calendar are frozen at this moment

A copy is taken. If the operator edits the template next week, your running season is untouched. This is deliberate and there is no way to un-freeze it — start a new season instead.

Work the stages

Each stage shows a status, and the status tells you what it needs:

STATUS	WHAT IT MEANS
Awaiting entrants	The stage cannot work out who plays. It will show you the rule and a suggestion. Your move.
Ready to generate	Everything it needs is known. Press the button.
Generated	Fixtures exist as series. Approve and release them from the series list.
Needs regenerating	Something changed after generation and the live fixtures no longer match.

Confirming entrants

Confirm entrants opens a table of every registered side with a group dropdown against each. The rule is quoted at the top, and a suggestion is pre-filled — for a swap, the previous stage's groups with the two sides already exchanged.

Use the suggestion accepts it in one click. Or reassign by hand. **Not playing** is a legitimate answer for a side registered in the league but sitting this competition out.

Live counts against the structure's expected sizes catch a miscount before it becomes a fixture list.

THE POSITION COLUMN

On a pool stage that feeds a cross-pool knockout, an extra **Position** column appears. Fill it in. The later bracket pairs the winner of one pool against another pool's runner-up, so the order inside each group decides who plays whom.

Without it the draw falls back to a seeded bracket over the same teams and says so on the stage card. Right people, wrong pairings.

Generating

Generate creates one series per group, named after the league and the stage. From there it is the ordinary path you already know: check the fixtures, approve, release. Clubs and players see nothing until you release.

REGENERATING A RELEASED SCHEDULE

If the fixtures have already gone out, regenerating replaces them and there is no undo. You will get a confirmation naming how many series are affected. Read it.

Stages wait for each other, and that is fine

A split league's first round generates and releases in September while the post-swap final round sits at **Awaiting entrants** until December. The season view shows both plainly, so nobody thinks half a season is missing.

EVERY CONFIRMATION IS RECORDED

Who confirmed a stage's entrants, when, what was suggested, and whether they accepted it. Relegation and points carry ride on these decisions, so the trail is a governance record rather than a nicety. It cannot be edited or shortened afterwards.

Allocating grounds

A separate pass, run after fixtures exist. It decides where each match is played.

What it is trying to do

In order of priority, and the order is yours to change:

1. **Home preference.** Play at the home side's ground.
2. **Distance.** Prefer the ground with less combined travel.
3. **Availability.** Prefer a quieter ground, all else equal.

When the home ground will not work, it falls back in this order:

home ground → the club's secondary ground → the away side's ground → the nearest available neutral ground

The ledger covers every competition at once

THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT THING HERE

Allocation looks at **every series in the union**, not just the one you are allocating. Premier Men 50 Over and Premier Men T20 compete for the same grounds on the same Saturday, and a side must not be scheduled twice in one day across two competitions.

Reading the result

STATUS	MEANING
Home	At the home side's ground, as intended.
Alternative	Moved to the away side's ground. The reason says why.
Neutral	Neither side's ground. The reason says why, with the travel figure.
Unresolved	It could not place this fixture and is telling you rather than guessing.

Every fixture carries a reason. That is the deliberate trade: a cleverer algorithm could squeeze out a few more kilometres, but it could not explain itself to a club secretary on the phone.

Hand-picked grounds are kept

Set a ground by hand on a fixture and re-allocation will not move it. It claims its slot before everything else competes, so a manual decision is never quietly undone. A padlock on the row shows which fixtures are held.

Two reports worth reading afterwards

Home and away balance per side — the crude alternation can leave a club with six home and four away. Worth a look before release.

Travel per club — minimising total kilometres can quietly dump the burden on one club. The per-club figure is the one that matters for fairness.

PART EIGHT

Worked examples

Four real competitions, exactly as they are configured.

EMCU Division 4 — the simplest thing that works

SINGLE STAGE

League season

Every registered side · plays every team once · every 2 weeks, Block 1

One stage, template untouched. The only unusual thing is the fortnightly cadence — and it is the reason to watch the preview rail, because eleven rounds at that cadence needs 22 weeks and Block 1 is 13.

KZNCU Premier Men · 50 Over Red Ball

STAGE 1

Double round

2 groups of 6, entered by an administrator · plays every team twice · weekly, Block 1

↓ 6th of the Top Six swaps with 1st of the Bottom Six, carrying points

STAGE 2

Final round

2 groups of 6, entered by an administrator · plays every team once · weekly, Block 2

30 fixtures per group in stage 1, ten per team — matching the union's own spreadsheet. The swap is the interesting part: it is a rule written in words, a suggestion the platform pre-fills, and a human decision recorded against a name.

KZNCU Premier Men · T20 Pink Ball

STAGE 1

Group stage

2 pools of 6, snake-seeded · plays every team once · weekly, Block 1

↓ top two of each pool qualify · set the **Position** column

STAGE 2

Cross-pool semi-finals and final

Entered by an administrator · knockout, cross-pool · Block 2

Snake seeding puts the top two seeds in different pools. The semis pair A1 against B2 and B1 against A2, then the final references the two winners — so the bracket reads "Winner of Semi-final 1" until the results are known.

KZNCU Promotion Men · Hollywoodbets Kingsmead Cup

SINGLE STAGE

Kingsmead Cup

9 sides, entered by an administrator · knockout, seeded · weekly, Block 2

The bottom ten minus the last-placed side leaves nine. Nine is not a power of two, so one preliminary match reduces it to eight, then quarter-finals, semi-finals and a final. The preliminary is derived automatically — you enter nine names and get the right bracket.

ONE DELIBERATE DIVERGENCE

The union's spreadsheet pairs its semi-finals in a way that would let seeds 1 and 2 meet before the final. The platform uses the standard bracket instead, which keeps them apart. The set of quarter-finals is identical; only the semi-final pairing differs.

PART NINE

What the messages mean

Everything the console might tell you, and what to do about it.

MESSAGE	WHAT TO DO
11 rounds × every 2 weeks = 22 weeks. Block 1 is 13 weeks — 9 weeks over.	The stage does not fit its block. Shorten the cadence, move it to a longer block, split it across two, or extend the block on the calendar.
Group B has no sides, so it generates no fixtures.	A group was left empty when entrants were confirmed. Reopen Edit entrants and assign somebody, or reduce the group count on the structure.
Group A has one side — it would play nobody.	Same fix. A group needs at least two.
Give every side in Group A a finishing position.	You are on a stage that feeds a cross-pool draw and a side has no position. Fill in the Position column for everyone in the group.
Group A has two sides in the same position.	Two sides share a finishing position. One of them has to move.
Paired as a seeded bracket, not cross-pool.	The qualifying pools do not line up with this stage's entrants. Confirm the pool stage's finishing positions, then re-check this stage. The fixtures are correct in personnel, just not paired across pools.
3 registered sides are in no group.	Clubs joined the league after entrants were confirmed. The confirmation is deliberately frozen, so open Edit entrants and add them.
1 side in a group is no longer registered.	A club left the league. Remove it from the group, then regenerate.
The entrants changed after these fixtures were generated.	The live series still hold the old groups. Regenerate to bring them into line — and read the confirmation carefully if they are released.
Only 40% of venues have a pinned location.	Travel distance was ignored for this allocation. Pin more grounds and re-allocate to get distance ranking back.
One of these sides already has a match that day.	The fixture is unresolved because a side is already committed, possibly in another competition. Move the date, or accept it and place the fixture by hand.
Every available ground is already booked that day.	More fixtures than ground capacity. Add grounds, raise "matches per day" on a two-pitch ground, or spread the round.

MESSAGE

WHAT TO DO

That competition points at a structure that no longer exists.

The structure was deleted after the competition was bound to it. Your operator needs to re-point the competition.

No structure configured for this league.

Nobody has bound a competition to this league yet. Ask your platform operator, or use **Create a series** for a simple league.

Reference

Who can do what

TASK	OPERATOR	ADMINISTRATOR	CLUB REP
Season calendars	Create and edit	Read	—
Competition structures	Create and edit	Read	—
Bind competitions to leagues	Yes	—	—
Venues	—	Create and edit	Read
Start and run a season	—	Yes	—
Confirm entrants	—	Yes	—
Generate, approve, release	—	Yes	—
Allocate grounds	—	Yes	—

WHY VENUES ARE THE ADMINISTRATOR'S, NOT THE OPERATOR'S

A ground going out for maintenance is a week-to-week fact the union office learns first. Routing it through the platform operator would make the schedule permanently stale.

Glossary

Block

A continuous stretch of the season during which matches are played. A season usually has two, separated by a break.

Cadence

How often rounds are played: weekly, every N weeks, on set weekdays, or spread evenly across the block.

Competition

One format stream inside a league — "50 Over Red Ball". A league can run several at once.

Cross-pool

A knockout that pairs one pool's winner against another pool's runner-up, so pool rivals cannot meet again immediately.

Group

A set of teams within a stage that play each other. A Top Six is a group. Each group becomes one series.

Preliminary round

An extra opening round that trims a knockout field to a power of two. Nine entrants need one; eight need none.

Season run

One competition being played out for one season. Holds which teams are in which group at each stage, and freezes the structure and calendar it started with.

Series

The existing unit of fixtures. One stage-group becomes one series, so everything downstream is unchanged.

Snake seeding

Splitting seeds 1,2,3,4 into two pools as A,B,B,A rather than A,A,B,B — it keeps the top seeds apart.

Stage

One phase of a competition. A split league has two: the double round and the final round.

Structure

The reusable shape of a competition — its stages, in order. Built once by the operator and used season after season.

Unresolved

A fixture the allocator could not place, shown with the reason. Deliberately visible rather than placed somewhere wrong.

Two things this does not do yet

Results and standings. The platform does not record scores, so no stage can work out its own qualifiers. Every standings-dependent decision is typed by a human and recorded. If results capture is ever added, the rules already written into your structures become automatic without you re-entering anything.

Scoring-platform sync. Not built. It needs the scoring platform named, its API documented, and a decision on how team identities map between the two systems.